

MOUNTAIN

Grammy-winner Kathy Mattea to perform in ENC

By ANIESA HOLMES

Daily News Staff

The sights and sounds of Appalachia are coming to the east when country singer Kathy Mattea performs in a concert that will share a special part of her life.

Presented by the New Bern Historical Society, the three-time Grammy-winner will be making a stop at New Bern's Riverfront Convention Center on March 4 at 8 p.m. With her acoustic guitar and Celtic whistle, Mattea and her band will perform songs that blend folk, bluegrass and gospel as well as Appalachian music from her latest album, "Coal."

"Our idea is that by the time I'm done, hopefully, you'll get one good belly laugh and tears in your eye at some point," Mattea said. "We'll try to make that evening a bit of a musical journey. We've done lots of older songs that I'm known for and some are rearranged to keep them interesting."

Mattea has recorded 19 albums, with more than 30 singles on the Billboard Hot Country chart and 16 top 10 hits with four reaching No. 1. It has been a surprising journey for Mattea, who was born and raised in the coal mining town of Cross Lanes, W.Va. Mattea described herself as a "whiz kid" who used music as a source of adventure.

"I skipped the first grade and my mom put me in all kinds of extra-curricular stuff to keep me from getting bored," Mattea said. "The only thing that stuck was music. It seemed like it didn't get old."

Mattea learned to play the piano at age six and got her first guitar when she was 10. In 1978 she halted her studies at West Virginia University and moved to Nashville. Kathy worked at the Country Music Hall of Fame while doing backup vocals for singer-songwriter Bobby Goldsboro and singing demos. She signed with Mercury Records in 1983 and her self-titled debut album was released in 1984.

Since then, Mattea has received rave reviews for her work, including the 1986 album "Walk the Way the Wind Blows" and top 10 songs, "Walk the Way the Wind Blows," "You're the Power," and "Train of Memories." Her release "Eighteen Wheels and a Dozen Roses" was released in 1988, and became the first single by a solo female to spend multiple weeks at No. 1 on the Billboard Country Singles chart in nine years.

"Coal," which was released in 2008, has been her most personal work yet.

Both of her grandfathers had worked in West Virginia mines, but it was the tragic Sago Mine Disaster that took the lives of 12 miners in 2006 that pushed Mattea a step further to record the album.

"Sitting with this music and singing it over and over and working with songs was really a personal journey," Mattea said. "I really wanted to tell the story of this way of life from this point of view... There was a whole group of people who work very hard behind the scenes who never get seen, much less honored. No one thinks about them until there is a disaster, so that was really satisfying."

In addition to traveling and performing nationwide as a part of her "Moving Mountains" tour, Mattea also teaches music workshops for students. Her next stop is a residency at Berklee College of Music in Boston.

Mattea is also preparing for another great honor as she will be inducted into the West Virginia Music Hall of Fame later this year. With the many albums, awards and concerts, the little girl from a small town in West Virginia has grown to see her dream finally come true.

"The idea that I could get a record deal and make my own records was sort of the ultimate and highest dream to get," Mattea said. "I love what I'm doing and that's everything to me and anyone who finds work like that is a lucky person."

For more information about Kathy Mattea, visit mattea.com.

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WANT TO GO?

Kathy Mattea will perform in concert at New Bern's Riverfront Convention Center on March 4 at 8 p.m. General tickets are \$40 and active duty military is \$35. Preferred seating with a backstage pass is available for \$125. Tickets can be picked up or mailed. Order tickets through the Historical Society office 252-638-8558 or online at newbernhistorical.org. Tickets also available at Harris Teeter, Mitchell's Hardware, and Bank of the Arts in New Bern, Harris Teeter in Morehead City, ITT Cherry Point and ASAP Camera in Greenville.

